



Fight for the ages: Jake Paul vs Mike Tyson at the AT&T Stadium in Texas, USA, was one of the biggest highlights of 2024. Even though the veteran started strong, the much younger and fitter Paul ultimately won by unanimous decision. GETTY IMAGES

Anish Pathiyil

anish.p@thehindu.co.in

The news of table tennis being excluded from the Glasgow 2026 Commonwealth Games struck a sour note, but the paddlers delivered several inspiring performances over the past year.

Sreeja Akula had her best year on the international circuit yet, winning singles titles in both the WTT Feeder and Contender series. She also registered an impressive win over World No. 2 Chinese player Wang Yidi during the ITTF World Team Championships.

Ayhika Mukherjee also braved the odds to beat World Number 1 Sun Yingsha, but the Chinese team proved too strong over the entire tie. Ayhika and Sutirtha Mukherjee rounded off a successful year with bronze medals in the

women's doubles and team events at the ATTU Asian Championships.

Italy's Massimo Costantini returned for a third spell as head coach of the national team as the men's and women's teams waded through their maiden Olympic campaign. The women's team of Sreeja, Manika Batra, and Archana Kamath made it to the quarterfinal stage, while the men's team lost in the opening round.

There was a fair share of farewell announcements too. Legendary Chinese paddler Ma Long called time on his Olympic career after helping his team secure the top spot in the